



Threat to Panama is a signal to China, too

In Latin America, Trump sees chance to challenge Beijing’s influence

BY KAREN DEYOUNG

President-elect Donald Trump’s threat last weekend to reclaim the Panama Canal was designed to make clear that “decades of U.S. commerce financing China’s growth and strategic footprint in the Americas is over,” according to a senior Trump appointee.

Successive administrations have allowed a “vacuum of control and influence” in the Western Hemisphere, Mauricio Claver-Carone, named by Trump as his incoming administration’s special envoy for Latin America, said Monday.

But those earlier administrations also included Trump’s first term, when his policy in the hemisphere focused primarily on migration and sanctions against Venezuela, even as Panama severed diplomatic relations with Taiwan and established ties with China in 2017. That opened the door to Chinese investments and companies that were already winning bids for major infrastructure projects elsewhere in the region.

Trump’s recent comments may reflect a newly muscular interpretation of his America First policy amid rising alarm about what the commander of U.S. forces in the region this year called China’s significant presence on America’s “20-yard line.” At the same time, the incoming administration may see Latin America as an easier place to exert foreign policy pressure — or at least the image of toughness — than some other parts of the world.

Following declarations that the canal is a “vital” U.S. “national asset,” Trump made a similar claim Sunday regarding another part of the hemisphere. In a social media post, he said that U.S. “ownership and control of Greenland is an absolute necessity” for American national security and for “Freedom throughout the World.”

SEE TRUMP ON A4

Retropolis: Under U.S. control, the canal’s racial divide was stark. A4

POWER GRAB



ADRIANA ZEHBRAUSKAS FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Left behind as data centers boom

Living on one of the largest swaths of land in America without electric power, Thomasina Nez’s entire life is a scramble to complete basic tasks.

To take a hot shower, she must wait for buckets of water to come to a boil on a small propane stove outside her wood-framed roundhouse. To make meals, she relies mostly on canned goods because unrefrigerated produce rots quickly in the Arizona heat. It’s a struggle to stay warm at night, because she refuses to use her coal-powered heater after its fumes killed her two dogs.

A fierce battle for electric power is being waged across the nation, and Nez is one of thousands of people who have wound up on the losing end. Amid a boom in data centers, the energy-intensive warehouses that run supercomputers for Big Tech companies, Arizona is racing to increase electricity production. In February, the state utility board approved an 8 percent rate hike to bolster power infrastructure throughout the state, where data centers are popping up faster than almost anywhere in the United States.

Thousands on Navajo Nation land remain in the dark, even as Arizona seeks to increase electricity production

BY PRANSHU VERMA
IN CAMERON, ARIZ.

But it rejected a plan to bring electricity to parts of the Navajo Nation land, concluding that electric customers should not be asked to foot the nearly \$4 million bill.

“We’ve been without [power] for quite a long time,” said Nez, who lives separately from her teenage children so they have electricity to complete their schoolwork. Tech companies “already have it,” she said, “and for them to get more power, it’s kind of not right.”

Nicole Garcia, a spokeswoman for Arizona’s utility board the Arizona Corporation Commission (ACC), said it did not approve the Navajo aid provision because of “con-

cerns about how the funds would be used,” adding that customers are not “responsible for extending electricity to all tribal areas of the state.”

Ann Porter, a spokesperson for the power company Arizona Public Service (APS), said that its process for raising rates is “backward-looking.” The organization aims to “recover money we’ve already spent and better align with the cost to maintain a reliable energy grid for Arizona.”

After a years-long courtship of Big Tech by local politicians, power companies and utility regulators eager for the promise of tax revenue and jobs, the strain on Arizona’s power grid is already apparent. Often, vulnerable communities are paying the price. While Nez and her neighbors lost a shot at getting power, the historically Black town of Randolph, almost 60 miles south of Phoenix, faces the expansion of a massive natural gas plant that emits particulate matter linked to asthma and lung cancer.

In 2022, the Arizona Corporation Commission halted a planned expansion of the

SEE DATA CENTER ON A11

Thomasina Nez, 49, lives separately from her teenage children so they have electricity to do schoolwork. Nez must boil water if she wants a hot shower and relies mostly on canned goods, since unrefrigerated produce rots quickly in Arizona’s heat.

Holy Door’s opening is a mixed blessing in Rome

Pope Francis inaugurates jubilee expected to draw record 32 million pilgrims

BY ANTHONY FAIOLA
AND STEFANO PITRELLI

ROME — Romans are gesticulating in overdrive and griping in snarled traffic as the Eternal City overhauls piazzas, fountains, bridges and tunnels. Even more are ranting about surging rents and greedy landlords poised to cash in on a coming tsunami of tourists.

On Christmas Eve, Pope Francis symbolically opened the sealed Holy Door of St. Peter’s Basilica, inaugurating a jubilee year that is expected to draw a whopping 32 million visitors to Rome — 10 million more than this year’s record high.

Jubilees are a Catholic Church tradition dating to 1300. They are considered a time for reconcilia-

tion and renewal. Catholics who visit designated sacred sites and engage in redemptive activities can obtain a jubilee indulgence — a sort of spiritual deep cleaning and mega-pardon for earthly sins.

For many Romans, though, this jubilee feels like a mixed blessing. It is set to give a massive boost to the tourism industry, a pillar of the Roman economy. It has also helped motivate Rome’s biggest facelift since the 1960 Olympic Games. With \$5 billion worth of projects funded by the national government, the city is transforming in ways that will outlast the pilgrims.

But the coming jubilee has left Romans living amid a giant construction site and has once again highlighted the double-edged sword of tourism.

The Spanish Steps are already overcrowded. Officials have been talking about how to limit the number of visitors at the Trevi Fountain. What happens when millions more people pour in?

From his office overlooking the

SEE JUBILEE ON A8

An electric return nearly four years in the making

Creator’s devastating injury left a beloved Christmas display dark, but he refused to let it stay that way

BY MICHAEL LARIS

Bill Vaughan limped through the grass, trying to perfect his spitting fish.

After hanging hundreds of thousands of Christmas lights, the skin on his fingers was cracked, his hand was smudged with blood and his mind was drowning in details. He was also feeling the pressure of time. He’d been building toward this moment for years. Now, it was December, and he wasn’t sure he could get his display done in a week — or at all.

He pounded rebar into the cold ground, then attached a bendy black pole lined with blue lights that when lit would look like a fish was shooting water from its mouth, ending in a nice splash. But he wasn’t sure if he grabbed the right pole, and the wrong one would throw off his intricate animation, so he trudged back to his workshop.

“I don’t move like I used to move,” said Vaughan, 69, who relies on a cane. “That’s why I’m

SEE CHRISTMAS ON A10



MICHAEL A. MCCOY FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

The Christmas display outside of Bill Vaughan’s home in Northern Virginia on Dec. 17. In 2020, he fell from a 16-foot ladder while preparing for that year’s display and sustained a severe leg injury.

IN THE NEWS

A very Trumpy Christmas The president-elect has been busy hawking branded Christmas gear, with the profits going to the family business. A3

Rebranding to paradise Once war-torn, the southern islands of the Philippines aim to market the area as a tourism destination. A6

THE NATION
Rep. Kay Granger’s situation has renewed scrutiny on the nation’s aging elected officials. A2
U.S. whooping cough cases hit the highest levels in a decade amid falling vaccination rates. A4

THE WORLD
A U.S. citizen held in Russia was sentenced to an additional 13 years on espionage charges. A7
With upheaval in Syria, the fate of camps holding suspected Islamic State militants is unclear. A8

THE ECONOMY
A technical glitch grounded all of American Airlines’ U.S. flights for about an hour, leading to widespread delays. A3
NewsGuard, which offers nonpartisan assessments of online publishers’ credibility, has become a GOP target. A9

THE REGION
Adnan Syed, subject of the “Serial” podcast, asked for a reduced sentence while challenging his conviction. B1
In an unexpected twist, an owl flew down the chimney of an Arlington home, which livened up a family’s holidays. B1

STYLE
Since the election, CNN has seen a 45 percent drop in prime-time viewership, raising anxieties at the network. C1

FOOD
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